

André Schepers <https://www.andreschepers.nl/>

11 September 2026, The Netherlands

Dear mayor Sjerps and aldermen,

I write to you with regard to the sailing accident that killed Tara when being present on a sailing boat that was part of the Brown Fleet, that was known to be dangerous and potentially lethal. This was known due to research. Sources are the media as you should know and should have known before this accident.

I wish to ask you through this letter, a full explanation of your actions, mayor Sjerps, and that of the municipality, so also the citizens of your town. In my honest opinion, this accident could have been prevented, and you, mayor Sjerps, should have taken political responsibility in the form of resigning.

To explain where my reasoning comes from, the following excerpt from this article to begin with:

<https://www.omropfryslan.nl/nl/nieuws/881132/risico-op-houtrot-in-scheepsmasten-van-de-bruine-vloot-nog-te-groot> - 24 april 2019

Te weinig met aanbevelingen gedaan

De Onderzoeksraad deed aan de hand van een rapport diverse aanbevelingen die de veiligheid aan boord moesten verbeteren. De raad concludeerde dat vakkennis over belangrijke scheepscomponenten zoals masten nog onvoldoende gewaarborgd is. Het onderzoek is onverbiddelijk: het ongeluk in Harlingen was geen incident dat op zichzelf stond. Ernstige houtrot komt vaker voor in houten masten van de bruine vloot. De aanbevelingen in het rapport zijn wel deels opgepakt, zo heeft de Vereniging voor Beroepschartervaart een platform opgericht voor de veiligheid aan boord. Toch geeft de Onderzoeksraad aan dat de betrokken partijen nog veel meer verantwoordelijkheid moeten nemen om hun plannen ook daadwerkelijk uit te voeren.

Onderzoeksraad: eigenaren ook verantwoordelijk

De huidige wijze van inspectie biedt dus geen garantie dat masten tot het einde van de geldigheidsduur in de keuringscertificaten veilig blijven. De Onderzoeksraad voor Veiligheid ziet graag dat er bij inspecties röntgenscans worden gebruikt om houtrot op te speuren. De raad benadrukt wel dat exploitanten en beheerders van schepen ook zelf verantwoordelijkheid dragen voor de veiligheid en niet alleen moeten wijzen op de wettelijk verplichte keuringen.

After the accident with Tara, apparently people woke up:

<https://www.omropfryslan.nl/nl/nieuws/1168115/bruine-vloot-doet-aan-preventieve-ruiming-van-oude-masten> - 13 september 2022

Bruine vloot doet aan 'preventieve ruiming' van oude masten

De burgemeester van Harlingen, Ina Sjerps, sprak zich vlak na het ongeluk fel uit. Volgens haar kon er van toeval geen sprake meer zijn na twee incidenten kort na elkaar. Blauw wil daar niet aan. "Je kunt vandaag ook met de auto voor de apk en morgen de motor kapot hebben. Dat je zoiets zegt, slaat nergens op. Laat ik eerlijk zijn: twee keer in één jaar is niet mooi, maar het blijft een incident op zichzelf."

The comparison of this accident with a car breaking down is interesting: An APK is done to check if it is safe to allow the car on the road again. Yes, it can break down, but that is not the reason an APK is done:

Bij de apk let de keurmeester onder andere op de volgende onderdelen:

verkeersveiligheid (remmen, wielophanging, schokdempers, banden, stuurinrichting, verlichting en carrosserie);

Source wiki: https://nl.wikipedia.org/wiki/Algemene_periodieke_keuring

These checks were also done with the Brown Fleet ships, and it was clear there was a significant risk the masts would break due to undetected wood rot, as we can read in the article above:

Het risico op houtrot in scheepsmasten van de bruine vloot is nog altijd te groot. Dat stelt de Onderzoeksraad voor Veiligheid naar aanleiding van enkele ongelukken met verrotte houten masten, waaronder het dodelijke incident in Harlingen in 2016.

In maart 2019 kwam er in Zaandam nog eens een persoon om het leven door een mastbreuk.

This brings us to you mayor Sjerps and the municipality, including the citizens of Harlingen. What responsibility did you take? If you know as a mayor of any municipality of The Netherlands, that there is a high-risk situation in which people might get harmed or killed, you have a duty of care to do everything in your power to prevent anything from happening. At the very least, you could have given very negative advice to anyone wishing to go on these ships to do so. My question is then: What did you do?

If you didn't know, how did that happen? How could you be the mayor without being aware of the dangers? Your predecessor should have known or not? When you took over, did your predecessor, mayor Sluiter, inform you of the dangers?

In my opinion, you should have known. If not, you should resign, in my opinion, due to incompetence. If you did, you acted in bad faith, in my opinion, choosing to not shut it down or do anything else if you didn't do anything. Therefore, also this letter: I wish to know what the situation was, and currently is: What are the policies to prevent this from ever happening again? Have you spoken to other municipalities? Have you spoken with the De Vereniging van Nederlandse Gemeenten (VNG)? Have they discussed this subject internally to take action when action should be taken? They will also get this letter and the question of what went wrong here. As also the high school Dalton Den Haag.

One final note: Our legal system doesn't allow getting retributive and restorative justice very easily. Unlike the United States legal system, citizens are not able to sue to get justice in all cases. The "polderen" model is active: "At the end of the day we all learned, and we moved on..." No! If you, for example, visit the homes of attorneys with the only consequence being a warning from the police in the form of a "Stop!" gesprek, you did not serve as a society retributive nor restorative justice to the attorney that is scared shitless now at home! The banality of evil that Dutch citizens are part of... In this case, if you are guilty of negligence, the parents and loved ones of Tara, deserve justice. I am going for that, because of the simple reason I believe you were grossly negligent together with the whole municipality and

citizens of Harlingen. The situation was not safe, clear facts. Only, when it is proven that the situation is safe, one should allow the situation, the ships, to be accessible again. You, a mayor in this country, are responsible for the safety of situations in Harlingen. You might say the ILT was in part responsible, but we had L'Être et le Néant, Jean-Paul Sartre and Simone de Beauvoir:

"I want to be in New York. However, I was born in a little village in France, that is the only time you don't decide place, and therefore you are not responsible for being there, but after that, you decide the place you are in and therefore the situation you have entered. That makes you in part responsible for what happens in those situations."

You stepped into the situation that is you fulfilling the role of mayor of Harlingen. The moment you started as a mayor, you are responsible for knowing how unsafe situations are. Not only that, also acting upon unsafe environments as we see with the infrastructure in The Netherlands: A bridge farts and it's closed. Zero risk!

After the accident, you were critical, you tried to be supportive, all actions that are part of your role, forgetting the part of your role fulfillment that is protecting people from entering dangerous situations in the first place. You can imagine how infuriating your behavior is to me:

<https://www.omropfryslan.nl/nl/nieuws/1167455/burgemeester-van-harlingen-wil-in-gesprek-met-bruine-vloot-ongeluk-met-charterschip-geen-incident-meer> - 1 September 2022

Burgemeester van Harlingen wil in gesprek met bruine vloot: ongeluk met charterschip geen incident meer

"We kunnen niet meer zeggen dat dit een incident was." Dat zegt burgemeester Ina Sjerps van Harlingen een dag na een dodelijk ongeluk met het charterschip Risico. "We houden van onze bruine vloot, maar het moet wel veilig."

For you, apparently safety is a "but it needs to be safe" aspect of reality. For me it comes first: "It needs to be safe, but we love our fleet as well... so we do all we can to make it possible for the ships to go out and set sail after we have guaranteed safety for the full 100%." For you, it seems more a thing of: "We love our Brown

Fleet so they sail, but we need to make it safe, and we will work very hard on this of course! After the calf has drowned..." No!

Of course, the Ministry of Infrastructure and Water Management will hear from me too: The ILT knows me, I know them, I'm coming this time with full destructive force after them. The safety in The Netherlands is NOT guaranteed right now especially not for our children.

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<https://www.andreschepers.nl>

P.S.: This letter can be found online:

https://github.com/andres81/Model_of_the_Psyche/blob/main/websites/dashboard-of-the-netherlands.andreschepers.nl/public/case-files/organization-for-the-protection-of-natural-persons/abuse_of_minors/letter-to-Harlingen-municipality-and-mayor.md